GENDER: THE OTHER FRONTIERS TO CONQUER



"Why is it that girls are given utensil sets and dolls to play with? Is it to condition them into believing that kitchen and home is their only domain?"

DR R. BINDU
Higher Education and Social Justice Minister, Kerala

"The fearlessness to ask questions is very important in a woman's life"

DR METHIL DEVIKA
Dance exponent and academic





"Seventy per cent of our employees are women. Most leave requests are for their child or a family member's illness. Why can't husbands take leave?"

MRIDULA RAMESH
Author and founder, Sundaram Climate Institute

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

crore, but it also has an unemployment of nearly 2.2 million. "So, we are trying to tell our people, why don't you take up the jobs yourself so that all this money gets rotated here?" he said.

On the political front, for nearly all southern states, the delimitation exercise slated for 2026 remains one of the most contentious issues. Leaders say it could adversely affect the southern states, which have so far kept their population well within check, something the northern part of the country has fallen short of. In fact, it led actor-politician Kamal Haasan to quip: "Just for good behaviour, we [South Indians] should not be punished." P. Chidambaram, the former Union home and finance minister, also noted that delimitation could cause either a loss or freezing of seats. "All political parties must sit and calmly think it through. Decision on this should be taken through consensus," he said.

Another heated session was "Who Will Win the South?", which saw three parliamentarians—Congress's Manickam Tagore, Bharat Rashtra Samithi's K.R. Suresh Reddy and CPI(M)'s John Brittas—alongside the BJP's Tamil Nadu unit president K. Annamalai talking about the general election next year. For the BJP, the year 2024 poses a challenge: of a total of 130 Lok Sabha seats in the South, the party currently holds only 29. In the recent Karnataka election, the saffron party ended up being driven out of its only citadel in the South. But Annamalai remains hopeful. "It is going to be a combination of development work that Modiji has done and the cultural renaissance." By the latter, he was referring to the recent Kashi and Saurashtra Tamil Sangamam programmes and the Sengol installed at the new Parliament complex. But, Reddy differed: "What will work in the South is performance.... you are competing against leaders who have performed really well." Congress general secretary in-charge K.C. Venugopal said though the Karnataka victory was a boost for the party, it will need the support of other like-minded parties to win in 2024.

Growing communal divisions was also a hot-button subject. AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi attacked both BJP and the Congress, declaring in his fiery speech that both parties had jeopardised the "social fabric"